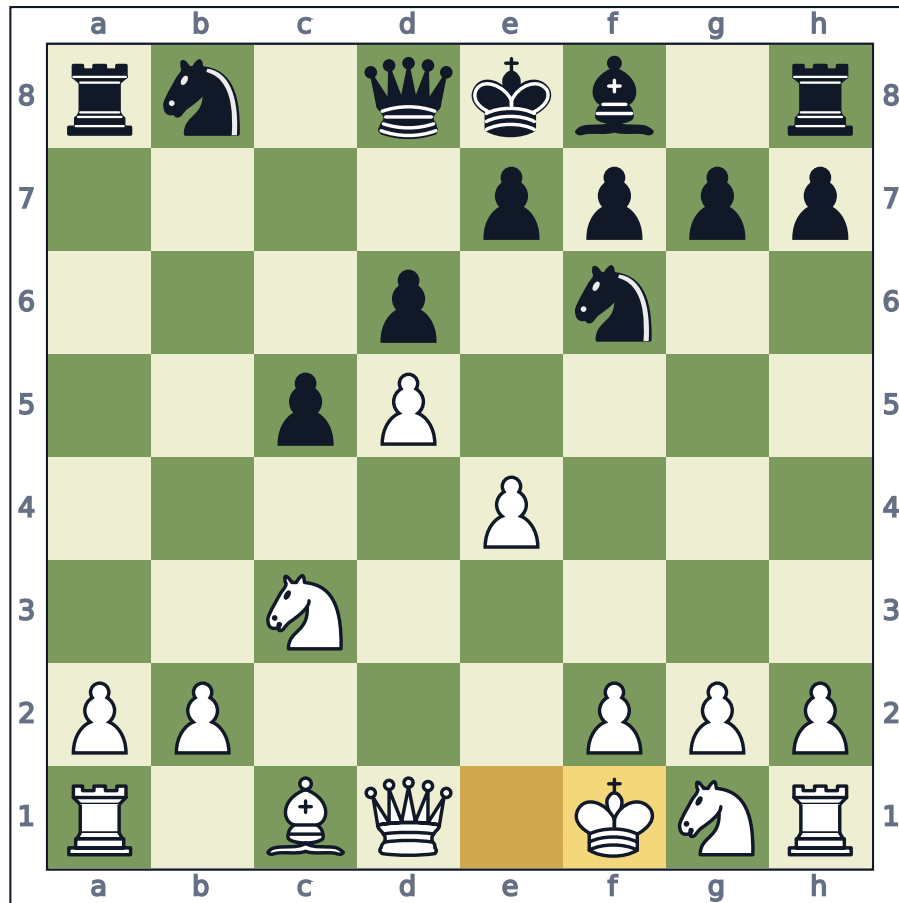


Benko Gambit

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

BLACK FOCUS

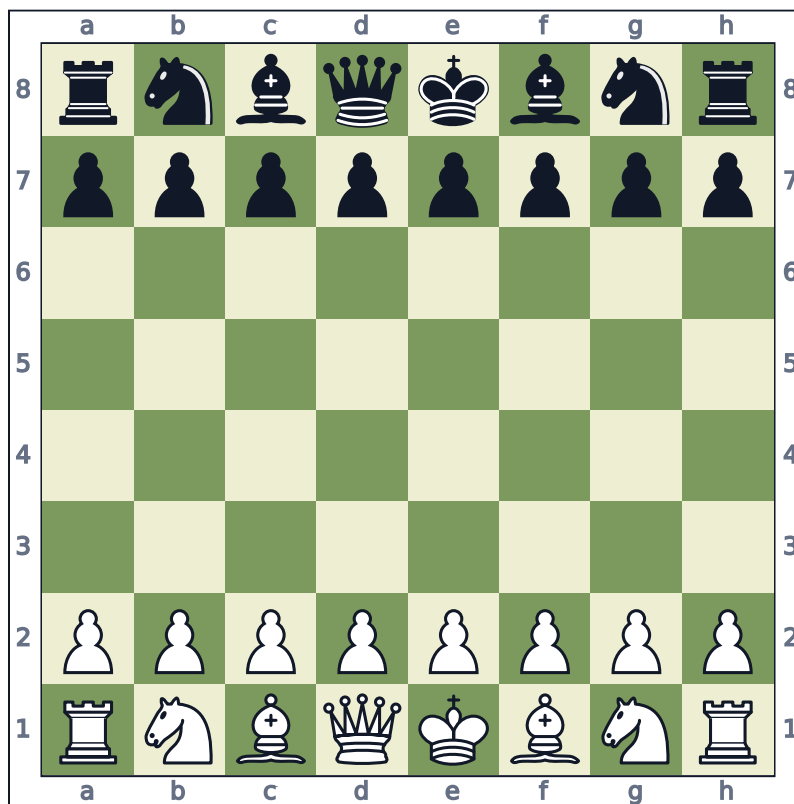
OPENING IDENTITY

Black sacrifices a queenside pawn for lasting files, diagonals, and pressure.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

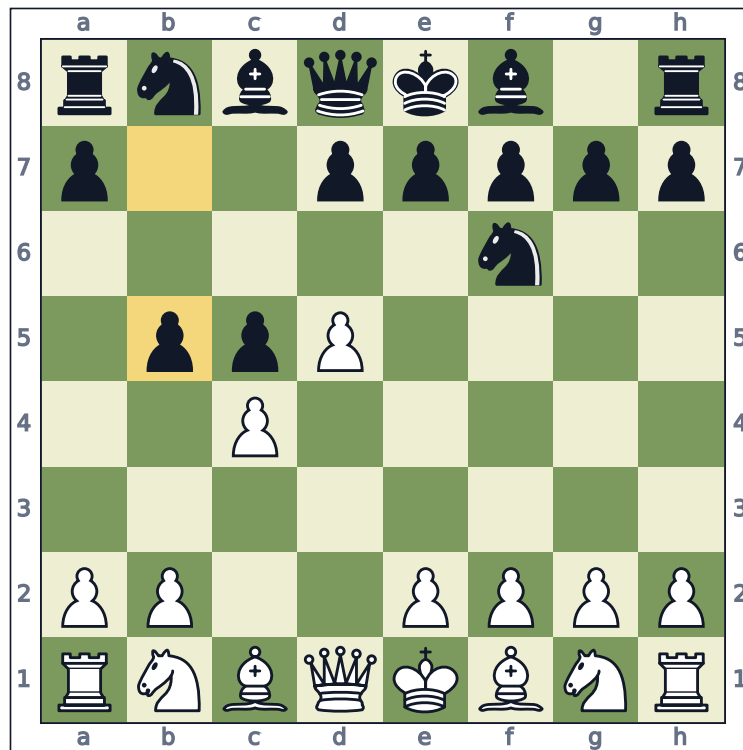
1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5

Course promise: The pawn buys files and lasting pressure.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5



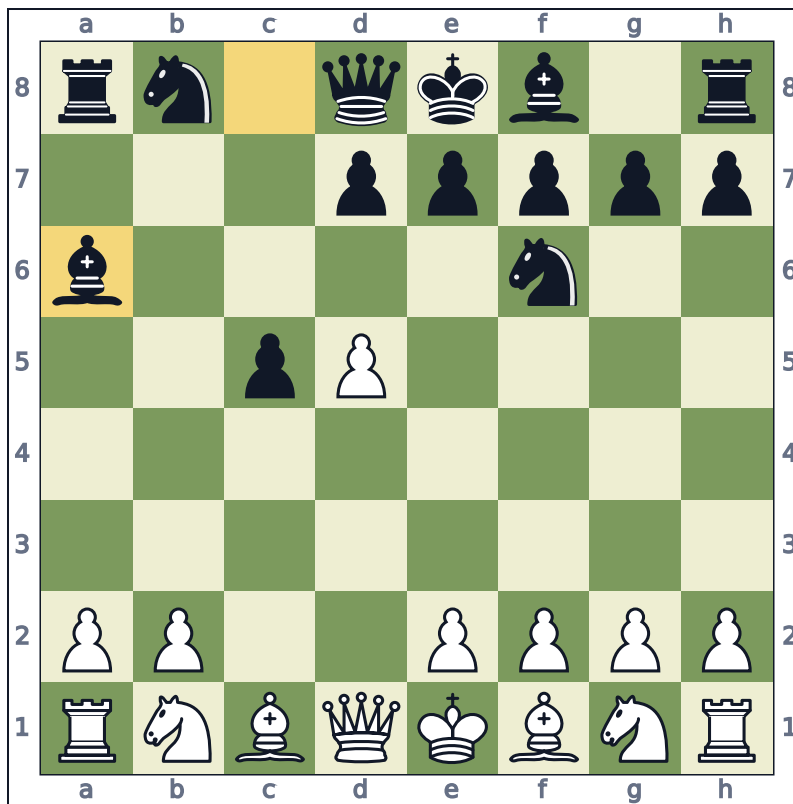
After 3. d5 b5

- 1. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... Nf6 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 2. c4 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 2... c5 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 3. d5 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 3... b5 - Gains wing space, but also changes squares that can no longer be protected by this pawn.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. bxa6 Bxa6



White to move

WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

Black sacrifices a queenside pawn for lasting files, diagonals, and pressure.

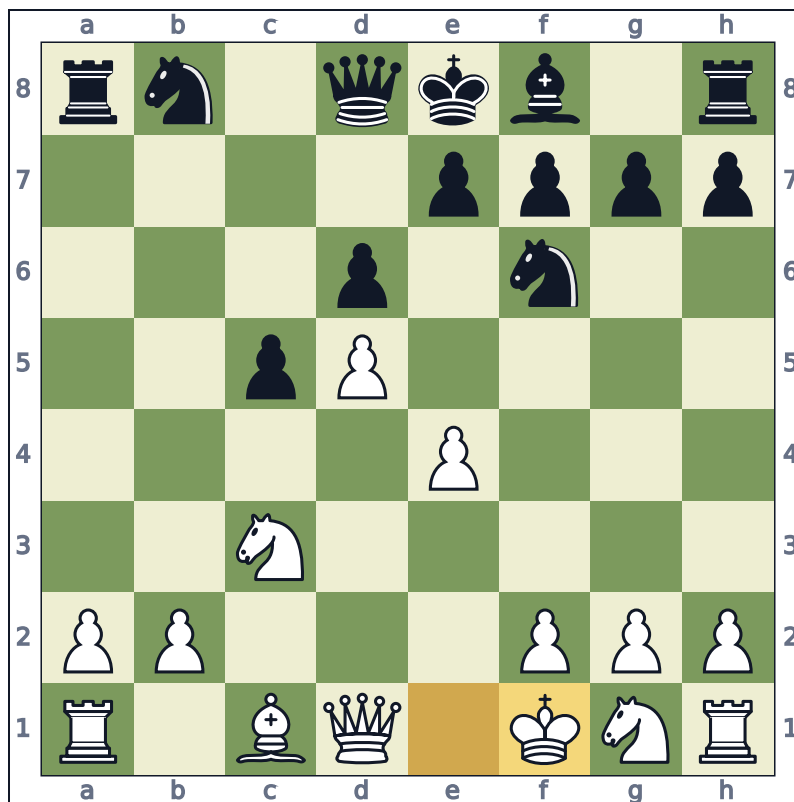
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. bxa6 Bxa6 6. Nc3 d6 7. e4 Bxf1 8. Kxf1



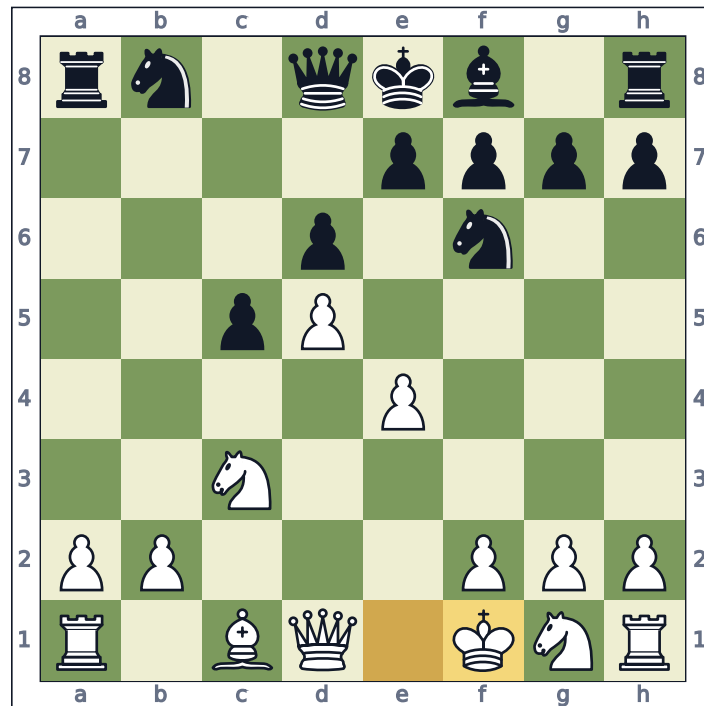
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: Black sacrifices a queenside pawn for lasting files, diagonals, and pressure. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Consolidate the extra pawn, complete development, and neutralize the a- and b-file pressure.

BLACK'S PLAN

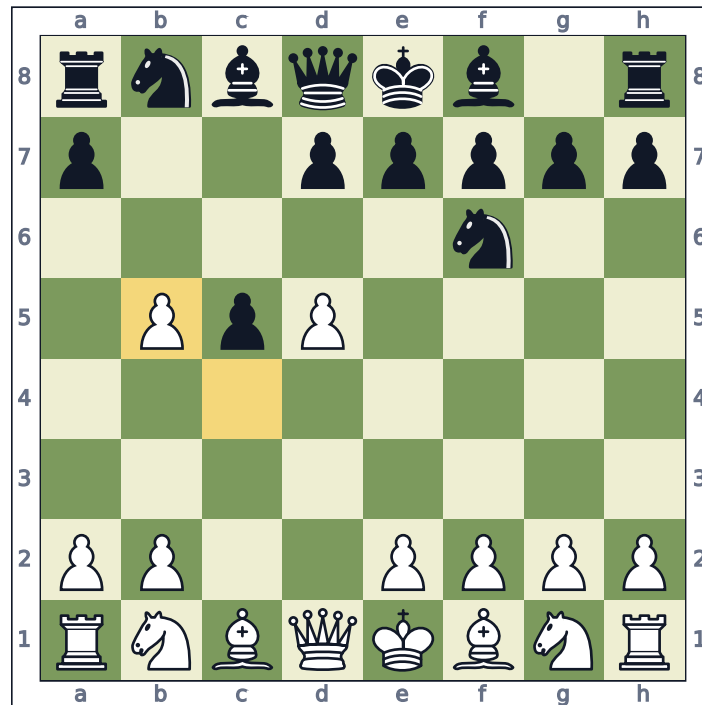
Activate rooks on the queenside, fianchetto, and keep the initiative rather than chasing material.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

...e6 attacks d5; ...b4 can disrupt White's queenside pieces.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - Black to move

THEME

The a6-bishop trade removes castling rights and can make the king awkward even without immediate tactics.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

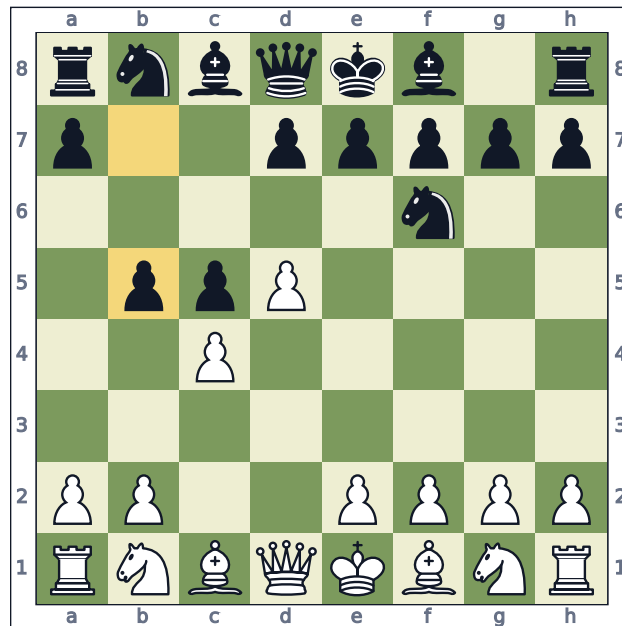
For Black, assuming compensation exists without placing rooks and bishop on their active lines.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: Black sacrifices a queenside pawn for lasting files, diagonals, and pressure.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

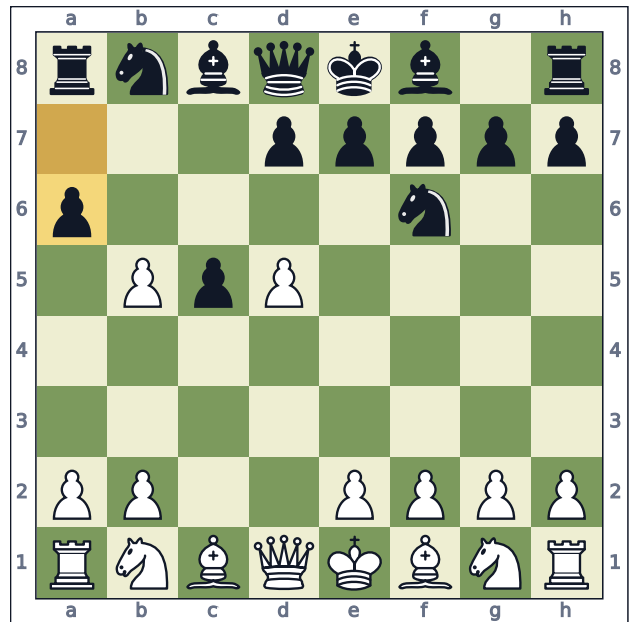
Return to the planned lever: ...e6 attacks d5; ...b4 can disrupt White's queenside pieces.

MEMORY SENTENCE

The pawn buys files and lasting pressure.

Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: d5. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: bxa6. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Consolidate the extra pawn, complete development, and neutralize the a- and b-file pressure. Black: Activate rooks on the queenside, fianchetto, and keep the initiative rather than chasing material. Lever: ...e6 attacks d5; ...b4 can disrupt White's queenside pieces.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.